

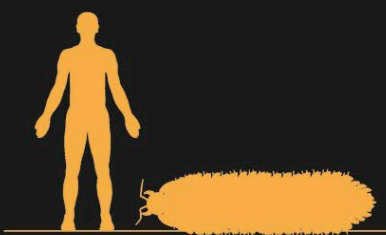
COLOSSAL CRAWLER

ARTHROPLEURA

This **gigantic prehistoric arthropod** (an invertebrate with a segmented body) was a relative of modern-day millipedes. Fossils of *Arthropleura* have been found in what is now North America and Scotland. At the time this creature lived, these regions were closer to the equator and covered in dense tropical forests. High levels of oxygen during the Carboniferous Period allowed *Arthropleura* to grow to huge sizes, unlike modern-day insects, which are much smaller due to the lower amount of oxygen in the atmosphere today. *Arthropleura*'s body is believed to have been made up of about 30 jointed segments, each covered by armored plates. These plates were only a few millimeters thick, but the lack of large predators meant that *Arthropleura* was safe in its forest habitats.

AT A GLANCE

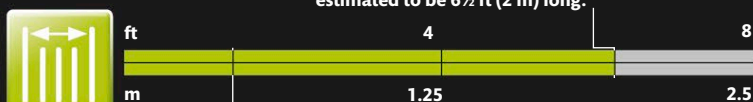
- **LENGTH** 6½ ft (2 m)
- **DIET** Living or rotting plant matter
- **LIVED** 315–299 MYA
- **HABITAT** Tropical forests



STATS AND FACTS

No complete fossils of *Arthropleura* have been found, as the body armor of these arthropods fell apart after their death. Some partial fossils have been found, giving scientists a rough idea of *Arthropleura*'s possible size.

LENGTH



The African giant millipede, the largest present-day millipede, is 1¼ ft (0.4 m) long.